

Chapter 23

Seeing people approaching in the distance, Yin Lingzhu grabbed Yan Si's wrist and pulled her into the practice room.

"Yan Si, what exactly do you want to do?" Yin Lingzhu stared at her, lowering her voice and shouting angrily.

Seeing her like this, Yan Si frowned in confusion.

"I just want to be with you." She spoke with a hint of grievance.

Yin Lingzhu heard the grievance in her voice, but having learned from the last lesson, she believed Yan Si was still acting, just like before.

"Yan Si, stop toying with me." Yin Lingzhu let go of her hand. She saw the red mark on Yan Si's wrist from where she had gripped too hard.

Yin Lingzhu looked at her own hand, the reddened fingertips very noticeable. "Yan Si, do you know what love is?"

"Love is hoping to give all the good things to the other person. Love is freedom. Love is the symbol of all beautiful things."

Yan Si fluently recited these words, as if she had practiced them thousands of times in her heart.

After finishing the last word, she stared intensely at the other person, like a child who had given the correct answer and was waiting for praise.

"But your love doesn't make me feel comfortable."

"Yan Si, you've been clinging to me these days. You think you love me, but this is just your possessiveness."

"I used to wait countless days and nights for you to come back, but you didn't. Yan Si! You didn't appear at that time!"

Yin Lingzhu roared out loud, venting all the emotions from this past year in this moment.

"What do you want now, clinging to me like this? Do you hope I'll change my mind and throw myself into your arms?"

"Yan Si, your love is like an expired drink to me!"

If a year ago Yin Lingzhu had still fantasized about having a romantic and thrilling love affair with Yan Si, then the current Yin Lingzhu only hoped her life could be like a glass of plain water¹.

Yin Lingzhu's eyes were red at the corners. She looked at the person in front of her, her hands trembling constantly, her voice also shaking.

"Yan Si, I beg you, please let me go."

"You had an affair, and I pretended not to see it. Even if you wanted my life, I gave it to you at that time."

"I was despicable. Now I just want a little respect. Is that possible? Just a little bit."

Yin Lingzhu raised her hand, wanting to use her index finger and thumb to show a small distance, but her constantly trembling hands made it impossible for her to even do this gesture.

Yan Si suddenly felt a stabbing pain in her heart, as if countless hands were grabbing at it, or like being pierced by tiny needles.

"You... don't be like this." After a long while, Yan Si spoke with difficulty.

"I won't... cling to you anymore in the future." Saying this sentence seemed to take all of Yan Si's strength.

Her shoulders, which had been straight and upright like pine and cypress trees, now drooped down like a deflated balloon.

Her whole person lost her spirit.

"Really?" Yin Lingzhu leaned against the wall, using its support to hold up her body, looking uncertainly at the woman in front of her.

Yan Si forced herself to curve her lips into a smile and nodded, "Really."

"You're free."

Yan Si quickly walked out of the practice room.

Yin Lingzhu watched her retreating figure. The black long dress on her body showed off her perfect figure.

But she only looked for a moment before withdrawing her gaze.

Yin Lingzhu and Yan Si ultimately weren't people from the same world.

Yan Si had countless rays of light on her—worth hundreds of millions, the youngest movie queen, CEO of a listed company.

While Yin Lingzhu was just an ordinary person making a living.

A year ago, she had vowed confidently that she would be the little Alpha behind Yan Si².

Recalling these words now, she smiled mockingly.

This past year had been her wishful thinking.

A vagrant accidentally picks up jewelry, but the jewelry doesn't belong to the vagrant. One day, someone will take the jewelry away from the vagrant's hands.

Yin Lingzhu thought absentmindedly—perhaps this was the last time she would see Yan Si.

She wiped away tears she didn't know when she had shed and walked out of the practice room.

After she had gone far, Yan Si appeared behind her.

Even the exquisite makeup on Yan Si's face couldn't hide her pale complexion.

She took out her phone with trembling hands, but didn't know what she wanted to do.

She only knew that at this moment, her heart hurt very much, very much.

It even hurt to the point of numbness.

For the first time, she felt the emotion of regret.

Yan Si opened her chat window with Yin Lingzhu. The screen was full of green messages with not a single white one.

Of all the messages she had sent to Yin Lingzhu, Yin Lingzhu hadn't replied to a single one.

So messages weren't notifications that just needed to be sent out—messages needed replies.

Yan Si scrolled up through the chat window. Gradually, there were fewer green messages, and white messages occupied the entire screen.

Scrolling to the first message Yin Lingzhu had sent, she suddenly felt a sourness in her heart, and tears involuntarily flowed from her eyes.

One drop, two drops—continuous teardrops fell onto the screen, making the originally clear words gradually blur.

How much joy and disappointment were mixed into those unreturned replies.

If time could go back, she wouldn't want those so-called tests.

Only now did Yan Si understand how ridiculously wrong she had been.

Those laughable tests of hers were carelessly squandering and consuming Yin Lingzhu's love.

She covered her eyes, but tears still kept running out through the gaps between her fingers.

As the tears increased, the friction between Yan Si's hands and phone decreased, and the phone crashed heavily to the ground.

Yan Si looked at the screen with cracks spreading across it. She felt that

the relationship between her and Yin Lingzhu was just like the cracks on the phone screen.

She pressed the power button with her hand—once, no response; twice, still no response.

Yan Si's heart felt somewhat panicked. She anxiously kept pressing the power button.

The phone screen remained black, with no sign of lighting up.

She frantically found the nearest phone repair shop.

"Hello, can this phone still be fixed?" Yan Si handed over her phone.

The shop owner put down what he was working on, took Yan Si's phone, and after opening it up for a look, frowned.

"You dropped this too severely. It can't be repaired—it can only be replaced."

The four words "can only be replaced" seemed to echo endlessly in Yan Si's ears.

Footnotes:

¹ **Plain water (白開水):** In Chinese culture, "plain water" often symbolizes a simple, peaceful, uncomplicated life—the opposite of the turbulent, dramatic relationship she had experienced.

² **Little Alpha behind [someone]:** A common Chinese internet expression meaning to be the supportive partner who stays behind the scenes, helping and supporting their more successful significant other.